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When the War was Over

The war was hardly over before the blame game began and heads started to roll. No one was surprised when Vengalil Krishnan Krishna Menon was sacked even as fierce fighting raged in the heights of the Himalayas. His left-leaning views were not a problem—many Indian politicians at the time leaned more to the left than to the right—but he was also the defence minister and was therefore criticized more than anybody else in the establishment for having underestimated the Chinese threat. According to Lieutenant General Brij Mohan Kaul, Chief of General Staff of the Indian Army during the 1962 War, India's intelligence gathering system 'compared unfavourably with that of the Chinese. They had systematically introduced agents into India in general and NEFA in particular (whereas we had lagged in this respect). Their agents built up a network for reporting back to the Chinese.'[1]

Even so, for several years before the attack in October 1962, intelligence reports had been pouring into the headquarters of the army—and Menon's ministry—about the Chinese military build-up across the northeastern border. Menon had at least three years' notice of the impending Chinese aggression.[2] Or, as the Indian journalist and political commentator D.R. Mankekar wrote in his book *The Guilty Men of 1962*, 'From 1959 onwards, Chinese belligerence was mounting up, until it burst out in a crescendo in October 1962'.[3]

Also according to Mankekar,

> Between the two schools of thought prevailing in the country at the time, Menon headed the one which played up the threat from Pakistan and underplayed the Chinese menace to India. Apart from his ideological bias in favour of China and other Communist countries, Menon had for long adopted Pakistan as his pet enemy, having for so many years monopolised the